RETURN OF THE FEAR FACTORY

Horror is seeing a revival in the Hindi film industry, with studios bolstered to greenlight audacious new voices and distributors seeing commercial viability in a genre that has been neglected in India for decades

By SUHANI SINGH

A curious phenomenon unfolded on the night of Thursday, May 28. Cinephiles in metros came in droves to watch *Obsession*, a Hollywood horror flick about a boy who uses a magic wish to get his friend to fall in love with him. There were nervous laughs, gasps and, eventually, goosebumps of thrill across the Hindi film industry. This film, directed by a 25-year-old and starring two unknown leads, had single-handedly faced down the notion that horror films don't make any money in India. With Rs 100 crore in domestic collections in just one month, it had become India's highest-grossing Hollywood film this year. Studios responded by announcing four horror films in June alone, including *Rooh*, a 'musical horror' with Emraan Hashmi, and *Odiyan*, Dharma Productions' first Malayalam film, to be directed by Rahul Sadasivan (*Bhoothakaalam*, *Brahmayugam*), the most talented voice in the genre for many.

Obsession's success in India raises an uncomfortable question: why is the most prolific film industry in the world severely short on ideas when it comes to delivering a Freaky Friday experience? Hollywood has horror subgenres like zombie, slasher, found footage, creature, body and gothic, just to name a few, but the Hindi film industry has, of late, largely stuck to the horror comedy, a subgenre popularised by Dinesh Vijan's Maddock Films with *Stree*, *Munjya* and *Bhediya*. This has come at the cost of the unadulterated scary film, the sort that Ram Gopal Varma and Ramsay Brothers would make,

▸ **ODIYAN: THE AGE OF ILLUSION**

This one is by Rahul Sadasivan, currently touted as the finest filmmaker in the genre having worked with stalwarts like Revathy (*Bhoothakaalam*) and Mammoothy (*Bramayugam*). He follows up his acclaimed *Diés Irae* (2025) with *Odiyan*, which tells the tale of a shapeshifting monster in 19th century Kerala, rooted in the state's folklore and myths. Starring Prithviraj Sukumaran and Manju Warrier, it is expected to be his biggest budgeted film till date with Dharma Productions on board as producers.



▲ **ROOH**

Emraan Hashmi features in this 'musical-horror' directed by Mayank Sharma (best known for